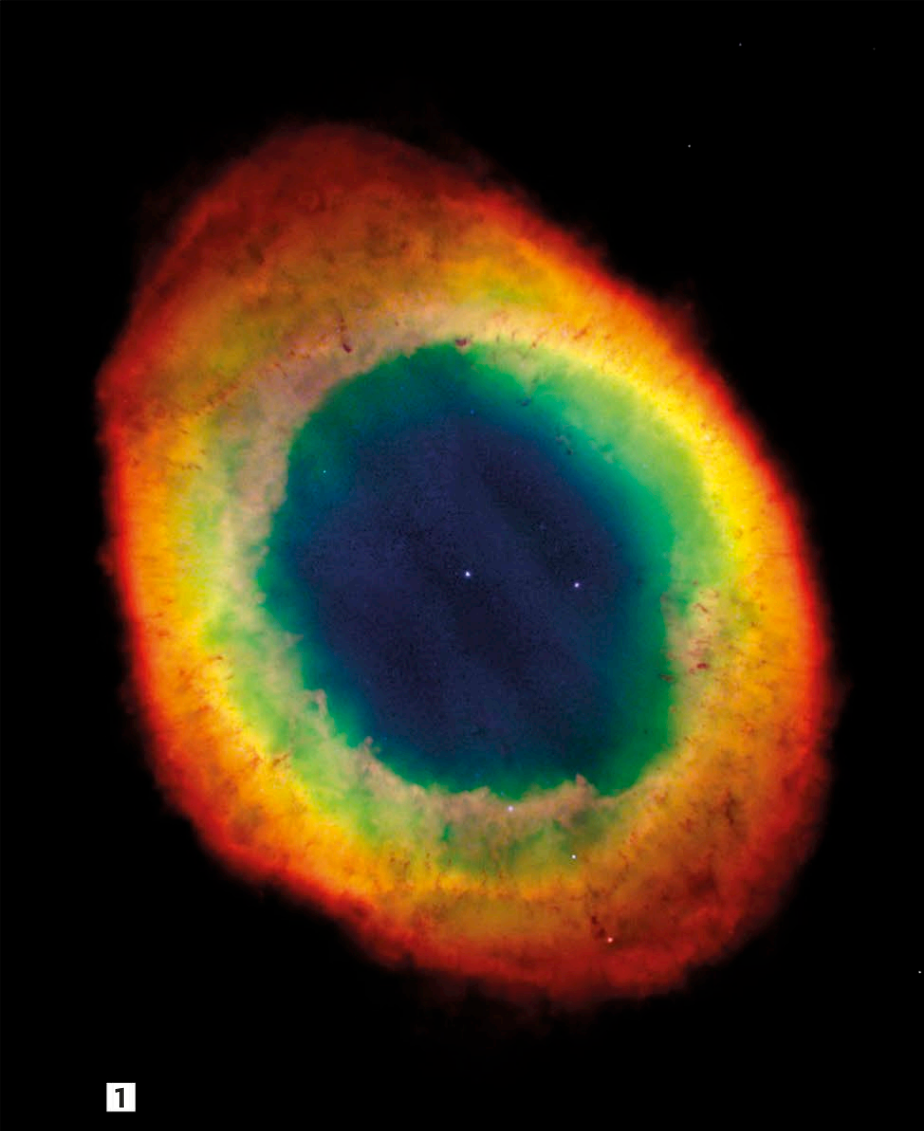
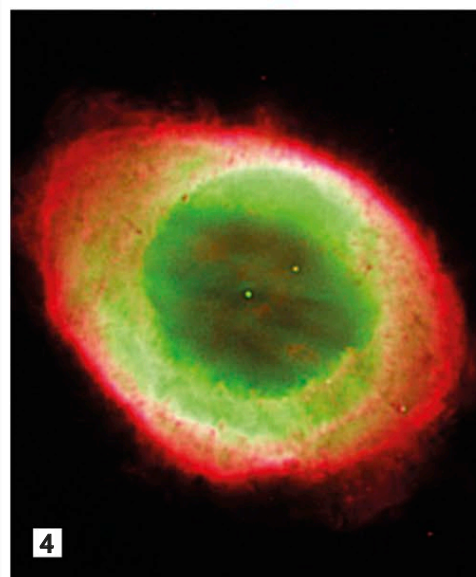




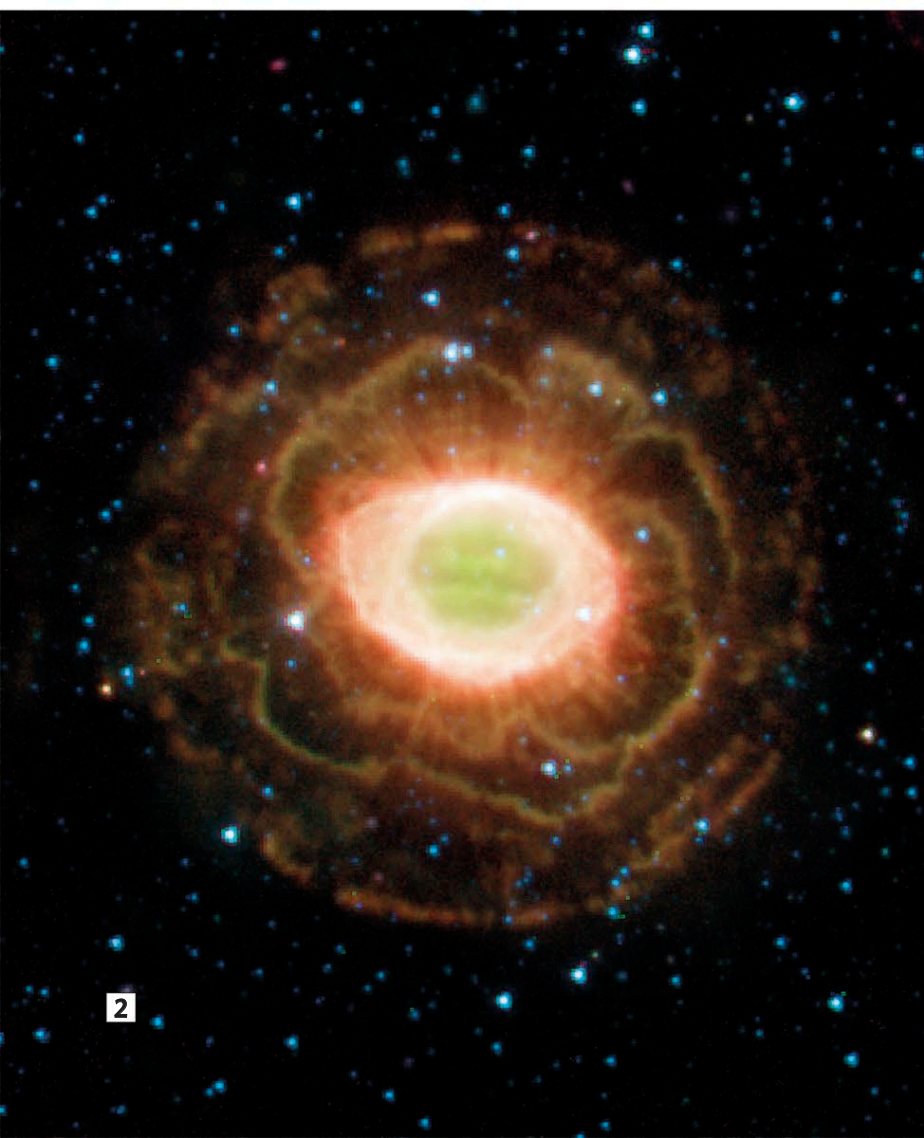
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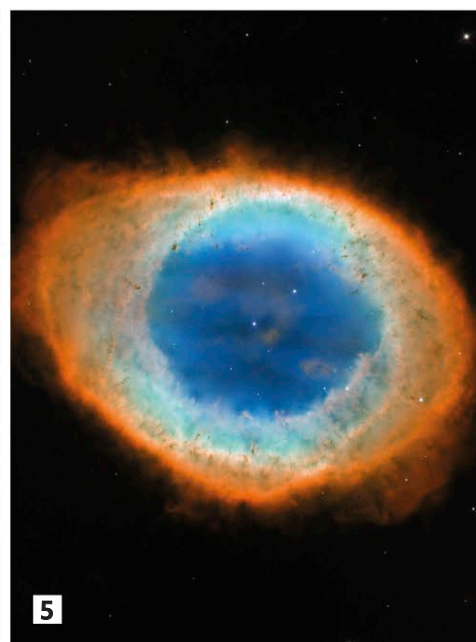
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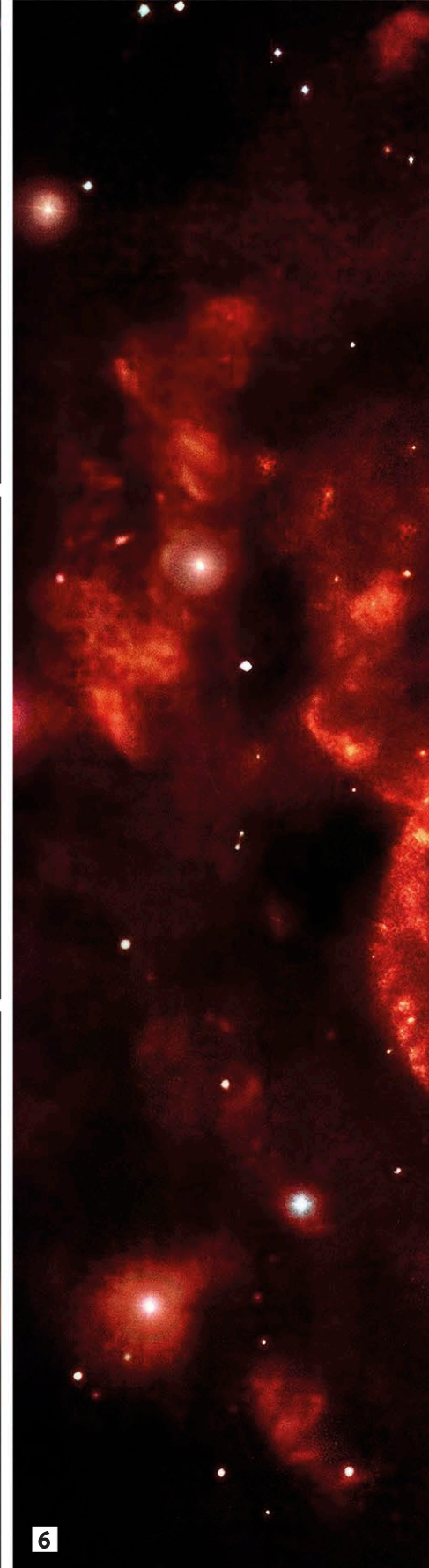
4



2



5



6

THE RING NEBULA

1 True colors

This Hubble Space Telescope image shows a composite view of the Ring Nebula. It combines images taken through filters, to isolate various elements. The deep blue is very hot helium, the blue-green is the glow of oxygen, and the orange and red indicates nitrogen. Ultraviolet light from the star energizes the gas, making the elements "light up" at different distances from the star due to temperature changes.

2 Outer shells

The Ring Nebula gets its name from its ringlike appearance. But in 2005 this Spitzer Space Telescope image showed that it is more flowerlike, with outer shells of material beyond the ring. Spitzer recorded infrared light from the shells' hydrogen molecules, unseen in visible light. This outer material was expelled by the central star during the early stages of its evolution into a planetary nebula.